

Carroll Facing Investigation From the U.S.

Perjury Inquiry Against a Target of Trump’s

By GLENN THRUSH and BENJAMIN WEISER

The Justice Department has opened a criminal investigation into E. Jean Carroll, the 82-year-old former magazine writer who accused Donald J. Trump of sexual assault, according to two people with direct knowledge of the situation.

The investigation centers on whether Ms. Carroll committed perjury in civil lawsuits against Mr. Trump, according to the person, who spoke on the condition of anonymity to discuss an ongoing investigation. Ms. Carroll won a \$5 million civil judgment against Mr. Trump that he had sexually abused and defamed her, which the president last November asked the Supreme Court to overturn. She also won a \$83.3 million civil judgment against him in another defamation case.

An inquiry into Ms. Carroll would represent the latest chapter in Mr. Trump’s retribution campaign, which has been carried out by Justice Department officials. A number of figures who brought criminal and civil cases against Mr. Trump have come under the department’s scrutiny, including James B. Comey, New York Attorney General Letitia James and other adversaries of the president.

Andrew S. Boutros, the Trump-appointed U.S. attorney for the Northern District of Illinois, opened the inquiry into Ms. Carroll, according to one of the people with knowledge of the situation. The investigation was reported earlier by CNN.

Todd Blanche, the acting attorney general, is said to have recused himself from the probe because of his prior representation of Mr. Trump, although officials from department headquarters have been involved in the inquiry.

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“What’s a good day to come in?” Millender asked when she called the clinic in July 2023, hoping to have an embryo placed inside her uterus within a few weeks.

The doctor then delivered the news that would upend Millender’s entire future. Her husband had revoked his consent. She could no longer make a baby with his DNA.

“We can’t move forward,” she recalled the doctor saying. “Our hands are tied.”

And with that, Millender arrived at the center of a contentious new debate dividing courts and couples across the country. As more women turn to in vitro fertilization to build their families — sometimes delaying motherhood into their 40s — some are wrestling with an unfamiliar set of moral and legal questions that arise when children are created in a lab. Among the most con-



DAVE SANDERS FOR THE NEW YORK TIMES

E. Jean Carroll won a sex abuse suit against President Trump.

The investigation comes at a volatile moment in a Justice Department that appears to be increasingly controlled by Mr. Trump, who has faced little pushback from department leadership as he accelerates his campaign of retribution against those who accused, challenged or defied him in the past.

Mr. Blanche has aggressively pursued investigations against

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DANIEL BEREHULAK/THE NEW YORK TIMES

Damage on Tuesday after an Israeli airstrike in Tyre, Lebanon. Despite a truce, Israel still bombards the country’s south and east, and Hezbollah fires rockets at Israel.

If a Couple Splits, Who Controls the Embryos?

By CAROLINE KITCHENER

More than anything else in the world, Erin Millender longed to be a mother. She already had a day care picked out, a Pack ‘n Play stashed in her basement. She’d tried Chinese pregnancy teas and midnight fertility ceremonies under a full moon in the Caribbean Sea. Whatever it took to have a child.

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She Planned for a Baby. He Nixed Consent.

tentious: Who has custody of those children before they exist? Standing on the street in downtown Manhattan, Millender took a cigarette out of her purse and started to pace. A few weeks earli-



KIM RAFF FOR THE NEW YORK TIMES

It might be Erin Millender’s last chance at becoming a mother.

er, in the doorway of their Brooklyn brownstone, her husband had brought up divorce for the first time. But surely, she’d thought, that was just a marital bump, the kind of conflict that might bring a couple closer together. Not one that could destroy the most painstakingly laid plans for a family.

A high-powered lawyer dressed for a big board meeting, Millender

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Few in a Pulverized Lebanon Think Peace Is Close at Hand

Prospect of U.S.-Iran Deal Doesn’t Raise Hopes

By CHRISTINA GOLDBAUM

BEIRUT, Lebanon — Once again, there has been a cease-fire in Lebanon for weeks.

And, once again, the fighting has not stopped.

Israel is still bombarding much of the south and east of the country. Israeli drones are still buzzing low over the skies in Beirut, the capital. Hezbollah is still attacking Israeli troops occupying Lebanese territory and is still firing rockets into Israel. The death toll is still rising.

And now — though a truce was declared in April, and there has been talk this week of a potential U.S. deal with Iran, Hezbollah’s sponsor — resignation is setting in across Lebanon that a meaningful end to the war between Israel and Hezbollah is not coming anytime soon.

Instead, Israel has vowed to intensify its military campaign in Lebanon and pushed deeper into the country beyond the territory it already occupies, ordering sweeping evacuations for two southern cities.

“I have no trust in either Israel or the U.S.,” said Ghinwa Ftouni, 42, in Baisariyah, a village in southern Lebanon. “Just listen to the massive bombing,” she added, as the thuds of Israeli strikes ech-

oed from a few miles away.

Her disillusionment reflects the past two years of war in Lebanon, but also decades of dysfunction in which the country has lurched from crisis to crisis, its fate often determined more by outside powers than by its own fractured leadership.

In 2023, Hezbollah began firing at Israeli positions in support of its Palestinian ally, Hamas. Israel responded with artillery, airstrikes and, the following year, a ground invasion. Although a cease-fire was declared in Lebanon in November 2024, Israeli bombardment continued in large parts of the country.

Then, in March this year, days after the start of the U.S.-Israeli attack on Iran, Hezbollah began firing at Israel in solidarity with Tehran, touching off another all-out war in Lebanon and opening a new front in the regional conflict.

The latest wars have devastated Lebanon, a country of 5.4 million people on the eastern Medi-

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PROGRESS IN TALKS The U.S. and Iran are near an arrangement that could lead to the reopening of the Strait of Hormuz. PAGE A7

A.I. Now Gives Scams a Slick Disguise. Here’s How to Tear It Off.

An email riddled with typos. A customer service agent with a thick accent. A blurry Craigslist photo.

Those used to be telltale signs of internet scams. But today, thanks to generative artificial intelligence, those red flags have mostly vanished. Low-cost chatbots, image generators and voice-cloning tools make it simple for criminals to produce pristine copy, create seemingly legitimate websites and even replicate identities.

BRIAN X. CHEN
TECH FIX

A.I.-powered internet scams have become so convincing that I confess I almost fell for one. While mindlessly scrolling through TikTok videos, I came across an ad for a pair of Hoka sneakers marked 80 percent off. When I tapped on it, a website loaded that looked like an authentic clearance outlet for the shoe brand.

But after I added the shoes to the shopping cart, my Spidey sense went off. A quick web search revealed that users on Reddit had been scammed by this site; Hoka had even published a warning about a surge of

The Shield Against Bots Even Includes Bots

fake web stores masquerading as its brand.

These look-alike websites are one of several A.I.-fueled internet scams that have recently been on the rise, security experts say.

The F.B.I. reported last month that cybercriminals had defrauded Americans of nearly \$21 billion last year, with about

\$893 million in losses linked to A.I.

Because A.I. makes it effortless to build websites and digital avatars, we may have to rethink our approach to protecting ourselves from online fraud.

“Instead of looking for indicators of what’s bad, now you need to be verifying if it’s good,” said Mark Beare, a general manager for Malwarebytes, an internet security firm. “It’s not a Nigerian prince anymore. It’s a look-alike site for REI or eBay or any one of those known, reputable brands.”

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A Cabinet Quick to Flatter

One of the most striking features of this term’s cabinet meetings is the extent to which President Trump’s leadership has been praised. Notably, some of these talking points are traceable to the president himself. Pages A12-13.

		
SCOTT BESSENT Treasury Secretary	MARCO RUBIO Secretary of State	LEE ZELDIN E.P.A. Administrator
‘You have saved this country.’	‘You’re the only leader in the planet that can bring the two sides together.’	‘He is willing to take a bullet for all of you.’



INTERNATIONAL A4-10

Basque Cheesecake Pioneer

Santiago Rivera, credited with creating the “burnt” confection in the 1980s, is ready to hang up his apron. PAGE A4

Guatemala Allows U.S. Strikes

The Central American nation agrees to joint operations against drug trafficking groups within its borders. PAGE A9

BUSINESS B1-7

U.S. Prices Rising at Fast Pace

Officials at the Federal Reserve have embraced the possibility of higher interest rates to get resurgent inflation under control. PAGE B1

What Would Bette Davis Say?

At the reworked Stage 5, a soundstage where Hollywood legends once roamed, there is a new attraction. PAGE B7

OBITUARIES A24

An Olympian, Like His Mom

The decathlete Russ Hodge was the first athlete to follow his mother into the Olympics on the U.S. team. He was 86.



NATIONAL A11-21

Bronx Zoo Star Is Dead

Happy, who was thrust into an unusual legal dispute, has been euthanized after a period of hospice care. PAGE A21

Mail-In Voting Changes Stand

A ruling lets the Trump administration pursue using the Postal Service to check voters against a database. PAGE A15

SPORTS B8-12

A Soccer Star Pivots

Christian Pulisic struggled through an inauspicious half-season with A.C. Milan. Now he’s hoping to turn the page as he assumes a leadership role with the U.S. World Cup team. PAGE B8

Trans Athlete at State Meet

Special rules will be in place as a senior from Jurupa Valley High School returns to the California state track and field championships to defend the titles she won a year ago. PAGE B12

OPINION A22-23

Rana Hanna PAGE A22



WEEKEND ARTS C1-10

‘Hacks’ Leaves ‘Em Laughing

The Emmy winners Hannah Einbinder and Jean Smart discuss the series finale, their offscreen relationship and why comedy is just like sex. PAGE C10

